



Towards a pragma-linguistic framework for the study of sensationalism in news headlines

Discourse & Communication

7(2) 173–197

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DOI: 10.1177/1750481312471668

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Abstract

This article sets out a framework for a language-oriented analysis of sensationalism in news media. Sensationalism is understood here as a discourse strategy of ‘packaging’ information in news headlines in such a way that news items are presented as more interesting, extraordinary and relevant than might be the case. Unlike previous content analyses of sensational coverage, this study demonstrates how sensationalism is instantiated through specific illocutions, semantic macrostructures, narrative formulas, evaluation parameters, and interpersonal and textual devices. Examples are drawn from a corpus of headlines of the ‘most read’ articles in the online outlet of the British mid-market tabloid *Daily Mail* compiled in early 2012. Sensationalized instances are identified through surveys and focus group discussions and subsequently analyzed quantitatively and qualitatively. The study is located within the context of media scholarship on news values and current trends in journalism.

Keywords

Attention, critical discourse analysis, *Daily Mail*, headlines, news discourse, newsworthiness, popular journalism, pragma-linguistics, sensationalism

Introduction

In the media, ‘information is not a passive resource waiting to be searched for and accessed. It is always in competition for people’s attention with other information’ (Durant and Lambrou, 2009: 28). News outlets, which compete for audience attention to secure their profits from advertising, try to make their information appear relevant, urgent or

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unusual. For this purpose they customize news through selectivity or enhancement, generalization or simplification, emotionalism or sensationalism. Journalism studies literature tends to treat sensationalism critically as a sign of declining journalistic standards – as a flawed journalistic style pervaded with trivia or drama that is ultimately detrimental to democracy (Allan, 2004). Yet it seems that to cover an issue in a way that engages diverse audiences without losing credibility requires considerable skill. Nevertheless, despite some attempts at exploring this feature of popular journalism (Ekstrom, 2002; Grabe et al., 2001; Pantti, 2010), particularly in relation to television newscasting, sensationalism remains an overwhelmingly ‘intuitive’ construct.

In media systems theory, symbolic capital is no longer seen in terms of the economics of information, but rather in terms of the economics of attention (Lanham, 2006). Since attention is scarce, effective ways of focusing it are sought, for example through a ‘rhetorical approach’ in which textual design and linguistic style can be manipulated to focus attention on specific content. The notion of ‘collecting attention’ becomes an issue for the critical researcher interested in exploring how ways of influencing what we pay attention to lead to ways we understand, conceptualize and evaluate our social reality (and whose interests are served by such ways). This article is part of a larger project devoted to accounting for the social, cognitive and discursive mechanisms of sensationalism understood as a strategy of focusing audience attention in press news reporting, which struggles to compete for audiences with other news media outlets. Here we concentrate on headlines (subheadlines and lead-ins), since they involve pragma-linguistic devices and semantic macrostructures that activate our epistemic and emotional resources, and frame our understanding of covered issues.

With respect to its discursive aspect, sensationalism can be operationalized in terms of certain preferred textual, pragmatic or linguistic variables. A typology of such variables could be extrapolated from a sample of sensationalist coverage subject to systematic quantitative and qualitative discourse analysis. However, such an analysis can only be conducted after specific instances of sensationalism have been identified by audiences exposed to them. It is thus important not to confuse two separate aspects of sensationalism: a *sensationalist* choice of topics to be covered (e.g. scandal, crime, sex), and a *sensationalizing* way of packaging information to make it appear more relevant or interesting. Since the focus here is primarily on the latter, a pragma-linguistic framework is being developed to study sensationalism without reducing it to content or thematic analysis.

At this point an important caveat has to be made, namely that sensationalism is not treated as an inherent formal property of some types of news coverage, for example, popular press (Conboy, 2002, 2006). It is not to be conflated with tabloidization, although one could treat sensationalizing as one of the many textual strategies used by popular press and online services to widen their readership base. Even though this particular study is conducted on the basis of headlines excerpted from a mid-market tabloid, it is not a case study of the *Daily Mail*’s headline style, much less of British tabloid rhetoric. Rather, it is a methodologically oriented project to provide for a framework to systematically assess the pragma-linguistic facet of sensationalism. As this is a pilot analysis rather than a full-fledged survey, the *Daily Mail* was selected as a source of headlines likely to be suitable for researching sensationalizing strategies. In fact, considering the falling circulations of the print versions of many papers, the material, consisting of 120 headlines, subheadlines

and lead-ins, was taken from the online version of the daily. One of the reasons for that has been that *MailOnline* features an updateable list of the most-read articles, which is helpful in pre-screening the articles that actually caught readers' attention, rather than relying on the judgments of the paper's editors and front-page designers.

To reiterate, in this article sensationalism is conceived of as a specific discourse strategy aimed at channeling audience's attention, which may well be resorted to by both popular and quality outlets. This definition has two implications for the methodology of the present study: 1) there are no stable form–function relationships between lexicogrammatical choices or textual patterns and sensationalizing, thus all conclusions reached in the course of this pilot study emerge from the data collected for the present corpus and are subject to verification, amendment and possible expansion in further research; 2) the identification of whether the strategy of sensationalizing has been applied depends on the perception and reaction of the audience, thus the study relies to a large extent on readers'/informants' opinions. Arguably, a methodologically sound study of sensationalism needs to bridge textual research with audience research.

This article starts from reviewing the status of 'news', arguing that, increasingly and across the mediascape, news is treated as 'constructing the extraordinary'. This seems to originate with the media professionals' sensitivity to audience consumption patterns in the competitive media context. One way to study this trend in news reporting is through the lens of 'news values' – the criteria for the selection of newsworthy issues. As it is claimed that language is an important resource for constructing newsworthiness, sensationalism is treated as one of the strategies to enhance news value. That is why the following section critically reviews selected media studies literature in an attempt at identifying the main approaches to researching sensationalism. The next section is devoted to a discussion of headline style – a review of studies on its general properties and functions – since it is headlines that bear the brunt of sensationalizing the news. Finally, the article presents the proposed pragma-linguistic framework for the study of sensationalism, with the description of the rationale, the sample material and the procedures employed in its construction. It identifies and exemplifies pervasive sensationalizing devices, focusing on illocutions, themes, narrative formulas, evaluative parameters, and interpersonal and textual devices.

News as 'constructing the extraordinary'

Traditionally, news tended to be described as current and objectively presented factual information that is important and valuable to citizens (see Allan, 2004; Hoynes and Croteau, 2002). Yet even a cursory survey of any day's newspaper headlines, broadcast news bulletins previews and online newsbites will reveal that much of the information prioritized there is not relevant to our personal, professional or even social experience. On reflection, it seems that the media fail us in providing 'important and valuable' news items (Ekstrom, 2002). In addition, the everyday intake of quick-paced, superficial and unrelated news has a desensitizing effect. It produces an impression of being well-informed, despite the fact that we are not being given a chance to analyze and assimilate the incoming information – a state once labeled by media scholars as narcotizing dysfunction (Postman, 1986).

According to Montgomery (2007), there is a need to redefine news, adopting a more realistic or inclusive perspective, as ‘information about current or recent events, happenings or changes taking place outside the immediate purview of the audience and *which is considered to be of likely interest or concern to them*’ (2007: 4, emphasis added). By adopting this more ‘audience-driven’ approach, we accept that every day there are decisions to be made in relation to what should count as news. These are based on a set of (constantly evolving) *news values* – institutional criteria for the choice of topics that are deemed as likely to attract audience’s attention. The literature on news values is extensive and it is beyond the scope of this paper to compare and discuss various classifications of news values (see Bednarek, 2006; Bednarek and Caple, 2012; Bell, 1991; Brighton and Foy, 2007; Galtung and Ruge, 1965; Harcup and O’Neill, 2002; Richardson, 2007). It is useful, however, to point out that some news values are related to the nature of events reported, some to the nature of news market, some to the qualities of news texts (Bednarek and Caple, 2012; Bell, 1991).

To summarize, priority is given to news issues that are recent, intense, and wide in scope and scale. Issues that involve conflict or negativity and concern elite persons and powerful organizations or countries are more likely to be covered. News that attracts the most interest should be unexpected, and yet ‘temporally bounded (...), unambiguous and clear-cut rather than cloudy and complex’ (Montgomery, 2007: 9). It should fit in with audience’s experience, have consonance with standard schemas of coverage and bear some kind of cultural relevance. Moreover, some news values specify how news stories are to be designed and written (Bell, 1991). This relates to whether the story is ‘exclusive’ to one outlet or is widely covered, whether it takes up a new issue or continues a previously signaled one, whether it uses predicable patterns of information arrangement or offers a mixture of thematic threads. In terms of textual composition, it matters that a story is not too lengthy, too complicated or too time-consuming for the reporter to prepare. The so-called ‘writing objectives’ also include: balance, accuracy, precision and color, but the actual realizations of each of those values may be problematic (Richardson, 2007). It seems that various configurations of news values determine the degree of ‘tellability’ or ‘reportability’ of particular stories.

Since news values are linked to the professional practices of media workers – from editors and journalists to presenters and technicians – they have become conventionalized routines in selecting, shaping and representing issues. For Ekstrom, news is largely ‘constructing extraordinary events’:

Journalism informs its audiences that something worthy of note has happened. Newsworthy events are of short duration and take place in a specific place; they are, what is more, something out of the ordinary, an aberration from normal everyday routines. If social, economic or political processes are to be made into news, something new, decisive, abnormal or deviant has to have occurred. Journalists are trained to spot potential events, even in what non-journalists might simply regard as ‘business as usual.’ Many of the events related by news organizations are of journalists’ own making. (2002: 266)

As a result, the underlying mechanism of sensationalism in news reporting, as explored in this article, is related to the journalistic practice of constructing events as

extraordinary. Admittedly, a number of issues reported in hard news stories may be indeed of some relevance to individual recipients, but the majority of them are not, and a routine practice is to present them in such a way that would justify spending time and cognitive energy on getting acquainted with them. News media professionals are aware of the fact that not all news items are of equal importance or relevance, even as regards their specific target audiences, but are determined to keep them attending to the outlet. Sensationalism is then a selectively applied discursive strategy to make a news item *appear* to be more important, interesting and relevant, and thus newsworthy, than it really is. This study focuses on examining the specific means of achieving that intended effect.

But sensationalism is not only about the choice of issues to cover. For example, and importantly for this study, Bednarek and Caple (2012) see newsworthiness not as intrinsically bound to news events, but rather as resulting from the application of various linguistic strategies. In accordance with their discursive perspective, 'we can conceptualize news values in terms of how newsworthiness is construed through discourse (both language and image). Newsworthiness is not inherent in events but established through language and image' (Bednarek and Caple, 2012: 44). In consequence, newsworthiness is something that can be managed discursively by stressing or foregrounding certain aspects of news stories. For example, the authors identify various ways through which newsworthiness can be enhanced: evaluative language; intensification and quantification; comparison, metaphor or simile; references to emotion; negative vocabulary (including collocations); story structure; references to time and place, nations and communities, individuals; inclusive 'we' and role labels; quotes from 'ordinary' citizens. As will be shown in the analytical part of this article, some of these strategic ways of making news headlines more appealing are not solely analysts' categories, since they have also been recognized by ordinary readers/respondents.

To close this section, it is perhaps important to make a few disclaimers. First, the pragma-linguistic framework for the study of sensationalism in news discourse is not aimed at explaining the phenomenon with macro-level statements. At that level, it could be said that sensationalism arises out of tensions between 1) the market forces and commercial interests of news media outlets, 2) the media professionals' conventional routines and concepts of audience needs, and 3) a variety of audience receptions, effects and gratifications. With this awareness of the contexts of production and reception, we deliberately focus on the micro-level textual instantiations of sensationalism on the basis of the information solicited from readers/informants. Naturally, audiences are disparate and fragmented; they approach news either actively or passively, reading news along normative or resistant lines, in different socio-cultural contexts and with strikingly different effects to those envisioned by analysts (Livingstone, 1998). In this study, however, we aim to trace commonalities rather than disparities in audience readings of news headlines, assuming that some texts are powerful enough to attract and keep readers' attention, even to make them react in similar ways despite socio-cultural diversities. Without claiming that there are limits to audience activity or resistance, we are concerned with textual patterns and pragma-linguistic devices that tend to prescribe certain cognitive responses, notably collecting attention.

Sensationalism in media studies literature

Sensationalism in journalism and media studies literature seems to have been debated and bemoaned more than systematically investigated. Unlike 'proper' or quality journalism, sensationalist or tabloid-style coverage has been criticized as detrimental to democracy (Cappella and Jamieson, 1997; McManus, 1994). Also, the umbrella term of sensationalism has been used fairly intuitively with respect to the shifting thematic priorities in news reporting towards so-called soft news. It has been observed that news items are selected for reporting to engage audiences emotionally rather than intellectually. Consequently, information that was relatively trivial tended to end up in main news reports. The trend was first quantified as an increase in entertainment oriented, human interest news from 11 to 40% between 1972 and 1992 in American broadcasting, as measured by Slattery and Hakanen (1994). This type of coverage was said to be replacing serious political and economic content. Subsequently, some media researchers interested in the scope of this trend turned to two methods: content analyses of news and ethnographies of editorial practices that underpinned it.

For example, in their content analysis McLachlan and Golding (2000) classified British news topics into 38 categories (agriculture, business, charities, crime, defense, diet–beauty–fashion, disaster–accident, drugs–alcohol, the economy, education, employment, culture–entertainment–showbiz, environment, equal rights, European Union, gambling, health, housing, human interest, justice system, local government, media, motors–cars, Northern Ireland, past events, parliamentary–political news, racing, religion, royal family, science, sex stories, social issues, social security, space, sport, transport, unions and other news). This list was then divided into sensational and non-sensational topics, with the category of sensational news including such topics as sport, crime, the royal family, entertainment, showbiz and human interest. In this way the ratios of sensational news could be calculated vis-a-vis the number of hard news stories, both in the course of time and in various mainstream media. And yet, content analysis, however nuanced in its categories, samples and statistical analyses, is not an empirically grounded method for determining the exact perceptual and cognitive effects of sensationalist/non-sensationalist coverage on readers.

Another problem with that type of research is its presumption that some topics are inherently sensational, while others cannot be so. However, as more recently demonstrated by Uribe and Gunter (2007), such a classification is not conducive to informed research on sensationalism. Their study shows, for example, that news stories traditionally classified as sensational – a term that implies a dramatic subject – do not necessarily contain more emotionally arousing features than other types of news story. They found that 'only crime stories (among the most frequently occurring "sensational" news categories) and, to a limited extent, political stories (a classic "non-sensational" news topic) provide clear manifestations of the presence of high and low emotion-laden attributes' (Uribe and Gunter, 2007: 207). It also seems that conflating sensationalism with emotional engagement impoverishes the field of study by excluding attention guiding mechanisms or pragmatic rules of mediated communication.

A persistent problem with the notion of sensationalism is thus its precise operationalization. Grabe et al. (2001), for example, assert that sensationalism can be understood as

the presence of news features that provoke emotional responses and physiological stimulation or arousal among the members of the audience. In other words, sensationalism is a process that places emphasis upon those elements that could provoke an effect on the human sensory system. This means that it is not only the content, but also the form of news report that may be traced as sensational. Throughout the last decade, more media scholars have acknowledged that formal features of news presentation (i.e. news packaging) play a role in contributing to the perception of sensationalism, especially with respect to television news (Ekstrom, 2002; Hendriks Vetten et al., 2006; Uribe and Gunter, 2007). Some inquiry has also been conducted with respect to how narrative writing styles, which staged a comeback in the 1990s with the deregulation of the press, have been instrumental in creating such effects as suspense and curiosity (Knobloch et al., 2004). From the reverse perspective, such phenomena as media panics, media hysterias and media hype have drawn researchers' interest into how print, broadcast and digital news had been packaged and relayed to make the immediate impact on audiences (e.g. Conboy, 2002; Richardson, 2007; Vasterman, 2005).

The majority of investigations into sensationalism as a trend championed by commercial media were focused on television news. Mainstream news bulletins overflow with disasters, accidents, violence, scandals, wars, famine, weather anomalies, breakthroughs, inventions, summits and celebrations of all kinds (Conboy, 2002; Grabe et al., 2001). In fact, TV news coverage is becoming so detached from our everyday 'ordinary' experience that it may well be consumed for its entertaining rather than informative qualities. Such research spotlights not only the choice of dramatic subject to attract attention, but also such audiovisual effects as the frequency of changes of camera positions, the editing techniques producing the 'eyewitness effect', the addition of background music, the zoom in/out transitions in perspective, the quick pace and shortened duration of news items, as well as the inclusion of vox populi or non-expert opinions into the coverage (Grabe et al., 2001). Sensationalism is predominantly studied with respect to newscasting, but it has also been discussed in the context of other media genres, for example, current affairs programs (Hendriks Vetten et al., 2006), and even spotted in popular science reporting (Peck McDonald, 2005).

The overall impact of sensationalism as a journalistic trend has also started to be re-evaluated. In view of the research into both journalistic practices and audience responses (Allan, 2004; Livingstone, 1998; Peters, 2011), it can be argued that completely non-emotional, 'just-the-facts' detached journalism tends to be avoided (see Pantti, 2010), although overtly emotionalized responses of journalists towards content are perceived as unprofessional, inauthentic and thus 'suspicious'. Sensationalism is being recognized as a popular journalistic practice aimed at 'crafting the experience of engagement' (Peters, 2011), and is more in tune with the spirit of popular culture than, for instance, the conventional norms of elite journalism and journalistic standards originating from a press-dominating era (Langer, 1998). Although no-one ventures to suggest that tabloid styles should be propounded, the idea that they pluralize the media-sphere and make it accessible and attractive to disparate audiences, some of whom, otherwise, would not have access to 'the public sphere' is quite convincing. All in all, covering an issue that lies beyond the immediate interest of a large audience in such a way that their attention is invested, without losing credibility and trust at the same time, calls both for a specific rhetorical skill and a heightened sense of the audience's needs.

Headline style

For the purpose of this study of sensationalism, we arranged for a pilot analysis of news headlines. Even with the spatial restrictions and institutional conventionalization, the headline happens to be an exceedingly multifunctional text-type. The dozen-or-so words of the headline must, for example, present the content of the article, attract audience's attention and generate interest in the story, as well as indicate the paper's attitude towards the issue. This is why most journalism handbooks widely discuss headline style and instruct trainee writers how to fit maximum information and stimuli in the fewest possible words. In some media outlets headline editors are responsible for 'customizing' reporters' titles to give headlines the desired qualities. If headlines are taken to be the part of news discourse designed to attract attention, the implication is that it is there that sensationalizing strategies are likely to be applied most often.

The literature on headline style is extensive and includes various perspectives. While earlier studies concentrated on grammar and lexical choices, including specific foregrounding devices (Fowler, 1991; Mardth, 1980; Reah, 1998), other researchers looked into the processes of construction of epistemic or affective stances through stylistic choices (Bell, 1991; Dor, 2003; Lennon, 2004; Ungerer, 2000; Van Dijk, 1988). Such studies often highlighted the role of headline style in directing readers' information processing (priming, framing, relevance optimization), or inferencing (recognition and appreciation of figurative expressions), or memory (suspense and curiosity stimulating devices). Some work on newspaper headlines focuses on the implications on their visual prominence and typographical attractiveness (see Kress and Van Leeuwen, 1998). Headline style has also been noted for its capacity to attract attention and cue humor through creativity, diction, wordplay, or styling of the oral mode (Chovanec, 2008; Conboy, 2006; Lennon, 2004).

In a typical print or online news story, the headline is treated as the main 'hook' for the reader. Indeed, it is sometimes so convoluted that one needs to rely on the subheadline and lead to elucidate its meaning. That is also why in some studies the headline is analyzed together with its lead/intro (sometimes referred to as *abstract*) as one structural unit (see Bednarek and Caple, 2012), which will also be the case in this study. Studies on headlines stress the multifunctionality of headlines, with the main purposes specified as summarizing, framing and attracting (Bell, 1991). This study reconsiders such order by spotlighting the last function, namely designing headlines to package information in such a way as to draw readers' attention. Indeed, recent media studies research demonstrates that headlines are no longer accurate summaries of the stories they lead because other imperatives – such as the pursuit of a reader's attention – cause systematic misrepresentations of the issues presented subsequently in articles (Andrew, 2007). Bednarek and Caple's (2012) approach also focuses on the capacity of headlines to increase newsworthiness.

Bednarek and Caple (2012) treat 'headlines' as a specific language style and point to some of the linguistic characteristics that make it different from other styles typical of news discourse. These include the omission of function words, frequent nominalizations and premodifications, the use of untensed phrases instead of clauses, the use of the present tense to increase timeliness, the increased frequency of adverbs of manner, the

decreased frequency of attributions and time specifications, the use of marked/emotional/evaluative words, the intertextual references in the form of pseudo-direct quotes or allusions, as well as such patterns as proverbs, idioms and puns. The function of many such stylistic choices is that of dramatization (see Bednarek, 2006). However, it must be stressed that headlines are marked for its variability and changeability. Also, with the evolving communication technologies (e.g. live news updates, newsbites, tweets), it tends to be more creative than reproductive.

Pragma-linguistics of sensationalism in newspaper headlines

Aims

The aim of this multidisciplinary study is to propose a preliminary framework for the study of sensationalism from a pragma-linguistic perspective. It has been motivated by two aims. First, the pragma-linguistic perspective seems to be missing from the methodological scope of media studies scholarship into such trends in news media as sensationalism. Media studies is often oriented towards a cultural critique of the results of corporate influence, technological advancements and political pressures on media industry. Second, in linguistics and discourse analysis, where news media texts are often subject to descriptive or critical research, the specific discursive practice of *sensationalizing* has not been investigated yet.

Among various language-oriented perspectives on media discourse, such as the critical, narrative/pragmatic/stylistic, corpus-linguistic, socio-linguistic, conversational, cognitive, diachronic, practice-focused approach (see Bednarek, 2006; Bell and Garrett, 1998), this study situates itself at the intersection of pragma-linguistics and criticism. This is because no description of media discourse can be claimed to be ideologically neutral, or, as critical theorists have argued, any academic description of a status quo helps to ideologically legitimize that status quo by virtue of implying its validity as an object of institutionalized inquiry. Importantly, criticism is not to be thought of as outright condemnation or rejection, but rather as an attempt at interrogating the categories and mechanisms that usually escape notice without deeper analytic insight and reflection. A critical approach is particularly important if the hidden elements work to control people's minds or perpetuate social inequalities (see Van Dijk, 1993). In addition, it must be admitted that such a project cannot be claimed to be empirical and based solely on quantitative parameters because media discourse is essentially a type of symbolic material, whose context-dependency and cultural situatedness bear upon the construction of textualities and meanings through interpretation.

Materials

As this is a pilot analysis, we selected the British newspaper *Daily Mail* as a source of data for researching sensationalism. The choice was motivated by the fact that the paper 1) has relatively high and solid circulation of approximately two million copies a day;¹ 2) is what is often called a mid-market tabloid (situated midway on the

continuum between quality press, e.g. *The Guardian*, and down-market tabloids, e.g. *The Sun*); and 3) is not particularly politically engaged (neither overtly conservative nor liberal), with a moderate editorial line and main preoccupations within social and celebrity issues. There is one more reason for the choice of the *Daily Mail* as a provider of analytic material, namely, its website (from which all the linguistic material was collected) features an updateable functionality – ‘most read’ – which works as a preliminary filter of preferences of online audiences with respect to articles on the *Daily Mail*’s offer on any given day. The sample, consisting of headlines, subheadlines and lead-ins (if any), was obtained by means of a systematic survey of the most-read list. The top 10 most popular stories were accumulated three times a week throughout the first four weeks of 2012, producing a sample of 120 entries (4562 words).

Procedures

The sample was not subject to any automated processing, as there are not any pre-determined coding categories that would lend themselves in advance to assessing the sensationalist tone of the headlines. In addition, pragma-linguistic means of sensationalizing news presumably do not constitute a closed class. Neither do we aim to establish any stable form–function relations between specific means, for example the use of colloquialisms, and their pragmatic effects, for example sensationalizing the coverage through cueing the oral mode. Instead, each headline was subjected to a qualitative assessment by three to four individuals and then discussed within focus groups composed of six to eight individuals (organized in three sessions of about 90 minutes each). The participants were college students studying in the English department of Opole University, who had some background in linguistics as well as cultural and media studies, but did not receive any specific information on newsworthiness or sensationalism. Their level of language proficiency in English was adequate for the purposes of the survey. The students were obliged to do the survey, but their participation in the focus group discussion was voluntary. The limitation connected with such a choice of informants is that they represent a fairly uniform segment of readers in terms of age, education and cultural background, but the fact that they were active news consumers, slightly distanced from the British media and socio-cultural context and willing to get involved in the project, ensured high quality of the elicited data.

The respondents were to assess headlines in view of the question: ‘How sensationalizing is the headline?’ using a five-point Likert scale (not at all = 0, not too much = 1, somewhat = 2, fairly = 3, very = 4). The informants were instructed to pay attention to formal (e.g. graphological, lexical, syntactic, rhetorical) aspects of the headline and not only to its thematic content. They were also asked to ‘identify the part of the headline that drew their attention most’. The focus group discussion was aimed at comparing individual results, establishing any prevalent patterns about the headlines and, if possible, naming the pragma-linguistic mechanisms responsible for making the entry interesting, relevant or appealing. Because headlines were assessed by varying numbers (4–8) of informants (some entries were left unrated), we calculated the mean for each headline. Since the procedure was a survey more than a coding process, we did not need to determine the extent of inter-rater agreement. The summative results of the averages of individual ratings are given in Table 1.

Table 1. The summative results of the averages of individual ratings.

How sensationalizing is the headline?	Number of headlines (total 120)
(0) Not at all (mean 0–0.75)	9 (7.5%)
(1) Not too much (mean 0.76–1.50)	25 (20.5%)
(2) Somewhat (mean 1.51–2.25)	32 (27.5%)
(3) Fairly (mean 2.26–3.25)	40 (33%)
(4) Very (mean 3.26–4)	14 (11.5%)

There seems to be a normal (Gaussian) distribution of rankings visibly skewed towards sensationalizing extreme: out of the 120 headline samples, over 7% were ranked as *not* sensationalizing, over 20% were assessed as *not too much* sensationalizing, over 27% as *somewhat* sensationalizing, 33% as *fairly* sensationalizing, and another 11.5% as *very* sensationalizing.

At this point, to sharpen the analytic perspective, we decided to exclude the part of the sample that was not ranked as unequivocally sensationalist: we removed all entries classified as *not* or *not too much* (graded 0–1). The remaining sample amounted to 72% of all the original entries.

Results of analysis

Illocutions. Considering the entries that were rated (2–4), our focus groups were tasked with identifying some of the main pragmatic strategies that make the coverage likely to be received as sensationalizing. These could be looked at from the perspective of the theory of speech acts. For example, it might be worthwhile to assess the relative frequency of the main types of illocutions performed by the press, that seem to have the perlocutionary effect of attracting readers through sensationalizing the news. The following illocutions were identified in the course of focus group discussions (in a bottom–up fashion, that is without any imposed classifications of illocutions) and the entries were categorized as in Table 2.

All these illocutions represent specific subtypes of *assertives*, with the exception of warnings, which tend to be classified as *directives* in classical accounts of speech acts (Searle, 1969). The following headlines seem to exemplify the typical illocutions rather well. They are listed in the order of the frequency ratings as indicated in Table 2.

- (1) £100 to play truant! Schools accused of bribing worst pupils to stay away when Ofsted inspectors call (6 Jan. 6)² *exposing*
- (2) Hate preacher to go ‘free in months’: Radical cleric cannot be deported say European Human Rights judges (18 Jan. 10) *speculating*
- (3) Rise of the hugger mugger: ‘Sociable’ thieves who cuddle while they rob (13 Jan. 7) *generalizing*
- (4) A sausage a day could lead to cancer: Pancreatic cancer warning over processed meat (13 Jan. 4) *warning*
- (5) Teen victim moves David Cameron to bring in drug-driving law (28 Jan. 10) *extolling*

Table 2. The illocutions identified in the course of focus group discussions (in a bottom-up fashion, that is, without any imposed classifications of illocutions).

Sensationalist illocutions	Percentage of ratings
EXPOSING (i.e. announcing and condemning a case of crime, failed policy, waste of money, personal misbehavior)	49
SPECULATING (i.e. announcing an issue and suggesting what its future consequences are likely to be)	21
GENERALIZING (i.e. extrapolating a trend out of an incident, passing a judgment about a whole class of people)	12
WARNING (i.e. generating anxiety about an issue and, optionally, offering suggestions as to how to reduce the possibility of falling victim)	8
EXTOLLING (i.e. announcing extraordinary facts, projecting events as historic, praising individuals for heroic acts)	5
OTHER/UNSPECIFIED	5

What can be observed at this point is that almost half of the sensationalizing news headlines are perceived as aiming to reveal information ostensibly hidden from the public eye. It is to be noted that most of the bits of news presented could be classified as negative (75%), some as positive (12%) and some as ambivalent (13%). The preferences for negativity and revelation could be correlated, since for the speech act of exposing or warning to take place, negativity of the proposition is a mandated felicity condition. The above finding is also compatible with the high premium put on negativity as a news value in constructing extraordinary events that pervade attention-drawing coverage. Since illocutions were identified as important categories, they should be important elements of the pragma-linguistic framework of sensationalizing, and more attention is needed in future studies to nuance the categorization of speech acts ‘performed’ in headlines.

Semantic macrostructures/themes. The next aspect of the analytic framework concerns the main themes or semantic macrostructures that can be identified in the corpus. The most common themes in the entries that were rated as sensational (2–4) included such categories as (in alphabetical order) *celebrity, children, crime, death, disaster, finance, health/safety, morals, public policy* and *sex*. It is difficult, and perhaps unproductive, to provide precise numerical data in this respect as some headlines involved several categories at the same time, for example,

- (6) Paedophile monk who paid schoolboy 50p each time he sexually abused him is locked up for five years (28 Jan. 1)

This one draws on the themes of sex, crime, children, morals, even finance, cumulatively for its sensationalizing character.

An important caveat to make here is that the purpose of this study is not to yield another content analysis of the most common themes in tabloid news reporting, nor is it designed to point out the coordination of dominant themes and latent news values. In fact the informants and focus group members were instructed not to reduce sensationalism to

sensational topics, such as the ones listed previously. What was discussed is how it was possible for topics that are not of general interest and relevance to be elevated to major news items. Consider the scope of relevance of the following case, however regrettable, that concerns an individual:

- (7) Student, 20, counts costs of cheap drink promotion after video of her dancing naked in nightclub paddling pool goes viral on the internet (28 Jan. 7)

in contrast to the possibly wider social relevance of the following with many people being affected by a specific policy:

- (8) Families 'will be 1,250 per year worse off' in four years because of tax and benefit reforms (4 Jan. 7)

What is interesting is that both headlines (7) and (8) ranked equal (i.e. 3.2 each) considering the level of sensationalism. It seems then that a pragma-linguistic framework for researching sensationalism problematizes assessments of hierarchies of importance and social relevance that emerge from content analyses of sensational coverage as practiced by media scholars. What is also important with respect to analyzing themes is that headlines are primary semantic framing devices. This means that their lexical choices and syntactic patterning are instrumental to how subsequent text is to be comprehended and evaluated. Even if the situation described in the article may in fact be more ambiguous and open to interpretation, the framing applied in the headline is likely to restrict readers' readings and judgments. This is why semantic macrostructures are to be integrated in our framework.

Narrative formulas. The narrative structure of news articles and its possible psychological effects have long been in the scope of media research (see Bell, 1994; Iedema, 1997; Toolan, 2001; Van Dijk, 1988). In this project, elements of narratology are used to explain why some headlines tend to be perceived as more sensationalizing than others. The assumption here is that since a story is broadly defined as a sequence of causally related events that involve characters, it can be claimed that various narrative sequences will have varying effects. For example, it is common knowledge that betraying the outcome of the story kills suspense, while starting with an unusual event generates curiosity.

From the analysis of folk tales, myths and literary fiction it emerges that the canonical story format involves *an initiating event, an exposition, a complication, a climax* and a *resolution*, usually following in chronological order.³ This order, in mystery and later criminal fiction, has been partly reversed to: *resolution, exposition, complication, climax* and *initiating event*, to put it schematically. In these genres curiosity could be generated by the reshuffling of the chronological sequence of narration. The intuition that the reversed order does indeed induce more curiosity, while the linear order produces suspense as a primary affective response, was empirically verified by Knobloch et al. (2004). Meanwhile, in journalism the dominant story structure that evolved due to the widespread popularity of 'penny press' is often referred to as the 'inverted-pyramid format' with the most important, constitutive information about the events preceding the

circumstantial, explanatory and contextualizing details. With print media centralization and market competition, news stories must begin with an attention-grabbing headline, which may correspond to the *climax* or *resolution* stage of a traditional narrative. The subsequent news story paragraphs typically elaborate on various aspects of the newsworthy event, usually with the least important information at the end (so that the editor can cut it out if column space is lacking). Iedema's (1997) study demonstrates that a newspaper report itself is not much of a story any more, as it almost never follows the chronological order. However, readers, who tend to be acquainted with this type of popular media text, can reconstruct the order of events relatively easily.

Additionally, the analysis of narratives of personal experience by Labov (1972) or Ochs and Capps (2000) enriched narratology with other important insights. Studies of oral memoirs, therapeutic interviews and banal everyday conversations have revealed a wide range of linguistic techniques for reporting on past events, particularly vis-a-vis the ways in which these events tend to be evaluated. This shows that stories are told not just for the sake of reporting, but because they have important social functions. For example, Labov (1997) uses the term *coda* to refer to the last clause of the story that returns the narrative to the time of speaking, thus precluding the question 'And what next?'. Apparently, with the coda, the condition of 'reportability' of the story has been satisfied and the motivation for listening to it has been exhausted. Other aspects of the story telling technique, according to Labov (1997), include credibility, objectivity, causality and the assignment of praise and blame. Such commentary on the consequences of the reported events may be spread throughout the narrative or concentrated in one section to constitute 'the point' of the story.

In this study around 30% of sensationalizing headlines were identified as having a narrative structure – at least two causally linked events involving at least two characters, albeit sometimes the character may be a representative of an institution (and be left implied). Headlines may reproduce the chronology of the sequence and thus become 'nutshell stories' as below, or not, as in (7) earlier.

- (9) Woman, 19, lured 16-year-old girl to house where she was plied with drink and drugs and gang-raped at knifepoint (20 Jan. 9)

And yet, the *orientation–complication–climax* narrative structure is fairly rare and, in the case of the above example, has not scored that high in terms of sensationalizing (mean ranking 2.1), despite being recognized as thematically sensational and exceedingly dramatic. What turns out to be much more likely to be conducive to the perception of sensationalism is a narrative arrangement in which the *climax* precedes the *complication*, usually because it is the first thing mentioned.

- (10) [Nurse who laughed] [as woman gave birth to stillborn child] [banned from working at a troubled health trust] (4 Jan. 4)[climax][complication][coda]
- (11) [Desperate mother has baby induced early] so [she can meet her dying 10-year-old sister.] [Loss of Katy's smile alerted her mother to specter of illness.] [Baby Scarlet brings the cancer-stricken schoolgirl happiness] (6 Jan. 5) [climax][resolution][complication][coda]

- (12) [Innocent man who rang 999 from back of police van] [while being ‘roughed up’ by officers] [gets five figure pay out] (1 Feb. 2) [climax][complication][resolution/coda]

It is not incidental that headlines also include codas in the sense of announcing the current outcomes of the dramatic stories, as is the case with (10) – where the arrogant nurse is said to be suspended, (11) – where the girl is reported to be happy despite illness, or (12) – where the victim is to be compensated.

The frequent use of the word ‘after’ in headlines to signal the *climax–complication* reversal is notable. Statistically speaking, ‘after’ appears in every third item in our corpus (i.e. in a headline or its subheadline or its lead-in, if any), as in:

- (13) [Paramedics left aspiring model] [to die at a party] [after he downed 14 shots of vodka telling him to ‘sleep it off’] (27 Jan. 9) [climax][resolution][complication]
- (14) [Humbling of MISTER Goodwin]: Four years [after the biggest banking disaster in British history,] [the man who caused it sees his knighthood shredded] (1 Feb. 10) [climax][complication][resolution]

To conclude, it seems justified to claim that the narrative structure *climax–(complication)–resolution/coda* is fairly typical of the sensationalizing headlines. Obviously, this concerns the headlines identified as essentially narrative, rather than as descriptive or generalizing, for example. The fact that readers are sometimes inclined to devote attention to following stories, despite having been exposed to the most important information right in the headline, suggests that headlines are ‘opening’ devices, which make readers invest attention to ‘seek closure’, and thus should feature in our framework.

Evaluation parameters. As it transpired already in the last two sections, sensationalizing headlines tend to express evaluative stances or pass judgments on pieces of news while announcing them. Indeed, one of the main observations about sensationalizing devices that was often raised in the focus group discussions was about the highly evaluative or emotive property of headlines. This aspect of sensationalizing could be analyzed within the framework of appraisal theory (Martin and White, 2005), or according to a parameter-based approach to evaluation (see Bednarek, 2006; Bednarek and Caple, 2012). In this study, it is worth taking the latter approach as a frame of reference due to the fact that it is based on newspaper discourse and tends to focus on the discursive enactment of newsworthiness. For example, Bednarek (2006) analyzes a corpus of a 100 newspaper articles (not just headlines) in order to shed light on various parametrical indicators of evaluation understood as constructing and maintaining a specific interpersonal relation between the speaker (the institutionalized press outlet) and the receiver (the target audience). She looks at how some core evaluative parameters, such as comprehensibility, emotivity, expectedness, importance, possibility/necessity and reliability, as well as such peripheral parameters as evidentiality, mental state and style, are distributed and functionally related to newsworthiness of news items in both quality and tabloid British press outlets. Here, Bednarek’s (2006) parametrical framework is used as a lens

through which we analyze headline evaluative style as a major strategy of sensationalizing. For reasons of scope, we restrict the analysis to core parameters, which nevertheless yield many insights on sensationalizing strategies.

First, in terms of the parameter of comprehensibility, the press may dramatize information by presenting it as having been ‘revealed’ or ‘explained’, thus implying that it was previously hidden or beyond the grasp of public opinion. The aim is to attract attention, to thrill or to justify reading about a trivial issue just because it was not available before. The impression that a mystery is about to be solved and the truth revealed is most conspicuously signaled with a provocative question in the headline, as in:

- (15) The Sainsbury’s solution to binge drinking? Cut the price of beer, wine and mixer cans (6 Jan. 8)
- (16) Why wasn’t he locked up? Sex offender killed woman, 95, after fleeing bail hostel and breaking into care home (18 Jan. 6)
- (17) Why did we ever knight Sir Fred? Miliband admits Labour was wrong to honour disgraced RBS chief (20 Jan. 3)
- (18) Are we about to witness the end of Britain? (28 Jan. 3)

About 8% of all headlines in the corpus feature an interrogative structure and all of them have been ranked as sensationalizing (2–4). Apart from that, the sense of (in)comprehensibility may be strategically achieved with vague/precise vocabulary and implicit/explicit attribution, as is the case with the above realizations of incongruity (15) or ambiguity (18). Bednarek and Caple (2012) also note the increasing vagueness of speculative news items that tend to be published before the process of verification is completed.

Emotivity is Bednarek’s (2006) parameter relating to the level of approval/disapproval of the issue being reported. Due to the high frequency of negative news stories (75% in our corpus), which corresponds to the media’s general embrace of negativity as a top news value, this parameter has been most often pointed to by our informants as decisive for their ranking of headlines as sensationalist. Explicitly, sensationalism is achieved through repetitive use of labels, as well as modifiers, that are negatively charged, as in the following (emphasis added):

- (19) *Greedy* bankers to face prison as Chancellor prepares new law to target *reckless* bosses who take risks with the economy (8 Jan. 3)
- (20) Covered in tattoos and *swigging* a funnel of ale: Fresh pictures of the *thug* freed from court for showing remorse (20 Jan. 10)
- (21) ‘Schettino’s a *braggart*, a *show-off* and drove the Costa Concordia like a Ferrari’, claims his former captain as ship slips even further into the sea (18 Jan. 2)

However, a distinction should be drawn between descriptive and emotive negative labels. Although such words as ‘guilty’, ‘damage’ and ‘dead’ are used to signify negative

aspects of social reality, they are low on emotivity and could thus be classified as primarily factual descriptors. By contrast, ‘assassin’, ‘mayhem’ and ‘forced’ are likely to express opinion rather than fact and thus are categorized as indicators of emotivity. Consider some examples of emotive headlines (emphasis mine):

- (22) Labour MPs *revolt* against ‘Barmy Ed and ‘Weak Ed’ for caving in to Tory agenda (15 Jan. 3)
- (23) Vilified for telling the truth: The Christian GP whose life was made *hell* after he questioned the legalize drugs campaign (28 Jan. 6)
- (24) Drugs, the teenager found *murdered* on the Queen’s estate and how the Baltic Mafia is *terrorizing* one of Britain’s oldest market towns (28 Jan. 8)
- (25) Four *radical* Muslims planned launching a ‘Mumbai-style’ *attack* on London, targeting the Stock Exchange, Boris Johnson and the US Embassy (1 Feb. 3)

In the above examples such negatively charged words as ‘revolt’, ‘hell’, ‘murdered’, ‘terrorize’ have been pointed to as being responsible for the sensationalizing quality of expression. In addition, such phrases as ‘radical Muslims’ (25) may be said to have achieved a high degree of attitudinal saturation (Bednarek, 2006; Martin and White, 2005), with negative evaluation being a part of evoked rather than inscribed meaning (Martin and White, 2005). This means that through being consistently repeated in negative contexts, they have accrued marked emotivity. Because deciding which words are high/low in terms of positive/negative emotivity is a matter of subjective interpretations, the data from the survey and the focus group discussion seem to be too superficial to offer a possibility for generalized observation. Doubtless, ranking emotivity will be crucial to assessing sensationalism in our framework.

The popular press is noted for framing coverage around the notions of deviance and scandal (Conboy, 2002). That is why sensationalism can be explored in terms of linguistic means of foregrounding the parameter of (un)expectedness. Presenting something as unexpected is likely to strengthen its emotivity (both positive and negative) (Bednarek, 2006) and is paramount to increasing interest in news coverage by constructing it as extraordinary (Ekstrom, 2002). Sometimes unexpectedness is overtly marked in the headlines with specific words or phrases (emphasis added):

- (26) How the brain starts going downhill at 45: Scientists find mental decline sets in much earlier *than they had thought* (6 Jan. 10)
- (27) Sales gloom as Tesco reveals its *worst* Christmas *for decades* (8 Jan. 10)
- (28) *Incredible* rescue of the two honeymooners trapped for two days inside stricken cruise ship as captain is arrested for manslaughter (15 Jan. 1)
- (29) Court hears of *amazing* double life of girl, 19, who disguised herself as a boy so she could date GIRLS (18 Jan. 3)

One exception could be the word ‘another’ – which indicates a recurrent, almost routine situation that is almost always negatively evaluated,⁴ as in the following (emphasis in original):

- (30) Now RB boss to get ANOTHER 8m bonus as he racks up 35.5m (and counting) in earnings from the taxpayer in just three years (29 Jan. 2)

However, the majority of the headlines do not signal (un)expectedness by a specific lexical means, but rather by virtue of its textual and institutional context.⁵ Indeed, the fact that the news item is broken as one of the *MailOnline*’s ‘most read’ stories guarantees that it must be extraordinary in one way or another.

The fourth evaluative parameter – importance – is signaled in various ways: from the use of capitals in print, to quoting elite sources; from references to eminent political and business figures, to citing statistics and sums that are likely to concern large portions of readers. According to Bednarek and Caple (2012: 141), such adjectives and nouns as ‘leading’, ‘major’, ‘top’, ‘senior’, ‘star’ or ‘celebrity’ are likely to draw attention to the news item by virtue of presenting it either as elite-related or of general interest and relevance. Importance is sometimes cued typographically with capitals, as the examples below illustrate (emphasis in original):

- (31) Republican race on knife-edge after one of the closest caucuses in HISTORY: Romney edges Santorum by just EIGHT VOTES (4 Jan. 8)

- (32) Humbling of MISTER Goodwin: Four years after the biggest banking disaster in British history, the man who caused it sees his knighthood shredded (1 Feb. 10)

Fairly systematically, headlines based on the projection of high importance of reported news are likely to use the superlative forms (e.g. 24, 25), hyperbolic expressions or overblown figures:

- (33) *Millions* face winter fuel bills of more than 500 pounds despite lack of demand due to mild weather: Tariff increases of 17.4% on gas and 10.8% on electricity mean soaring energy bills (4 Jan. 6)

Closer analysis of the sample reveals that 30% of *MailOnline*’s gathered headlines report on some financial data, feature an estimate of cost or frequency, or a calculation of an average presented with a mathematical or lexical numerical.

Evaluation in terms of possibility/necessity and reliability (Bednarek’s, 2006, fifth and sixth core parameters) is most often expressed in our corpus with modal verbs and adverbs. These may be used a) for emphasis or impression of urgency as well as for implying or shifting blame, as below for example (emphases added):

- (34) Nurses *must* be told to ‘talk to patients’: PM’s intervention is a damning indictment of care on our hospital wards. Nurses *should* check whether patients need help at least once an hour. David Cameron says quality of care has been hit by the stifling bureaucracy (6 Jan. 4)

b) for expressions of either sympathy or criticism, for example, invoking disapproval, indignation or outrage:

- (35) You *may* one day be Queen, but you *will* still need a criminal records check: Even Kate *has to* be vetted so she *can* go camping with the Scouts (6 Jan. 3)

c) for predicting (mostly) unpleasant future developments, for example:

- (36) We would use force to keep Gulf open: Hammond warns Iran not to block key oil route. Defence Secretary warned Teheran regime that UK will not tolerate the very significant consequences of a threat to block the Strait of Hormuz (6 Jan. 9)
- (37) The great sell-off: Property tycoon to raise 3bn by selling 1% of ALL UK homes to clear his debts (29 Jan. 5)

It must be stressed here that, in view of the fact that such a restricted sample as ours and such a simplified approach to evaluative parameters in comparison to Bednarek's (2006) original taxonomy as applied here nevertheless yielded so many insights, evaluation is an important element of the framework we are proposing for the study of sensationalism.

Interpersonal and textual devices. In the course of focus group discussions, participants pointed to some other aspects of headline style that may be treated as purposefully designed to sensationalize the news item. Some of them involve typically pragmatic categories, such as deixis. In particular, proximal indexicals of place ('here') and time ('now'), as well as personal and social deixis – the use of inclusive 'we' and social categories 'us' versus 'them' – may be used for the purpose of dramatizing news stories as well as reinforcing stereotypical representations (emphasis added):

- (38) *Now* more cracks have been found in the wings of the world's biggest jets ... but Airbus STILL claims they are safe to fly (20 Jan. 4)
- (39) *Now* expenses whistleblower MP has HIS claims probed (8 Jan. 9)
- (40) Incompetent *foreign* doctors who can't speak English are putting NHS patients at risk: Two senior doctors demand urgent action (11 Jan. 6)

The use of social deixis is closely connected with how alliances and enmities are constructed textually with the aid of terms of address, stylistic choices and power/solidarity projecting devices:

- (41) Well that's gratitude! We give India 1bn in aid, THEY snub the UK and give France 13bn jet contract (1 Feb. 7)

Interpersonal relations between senders and receivers established through a mediated text are a rich ground for exploration; yet here the main focus is on the discursive strategies of building trust and confidentiality through casual register. Indeed, stylistic cueing of the oral mode (Fowler, 1991) has been identified by informants as one of the *Daily Mail's* chief sensationalizing strategies. Stylistic shifts between the neutral register of the news report, technical/legal jargon, and colloquial lexis and structure are relatively common in the headlines, particularly whenever quotations are embedded there. Interestingly, some headline expressions can be treated as 'mind-reading', since they attribute to the

news story actors some words and thoughts that were never verbalized (this may even relate to animals!):

- (42) Salmond: I'll order police to sabotage an early referendum on independence (15 Jan. 10)
- (43) Capitan Coward: I only left because I FELL into lifeboat when ship listed suddenly as I was trying to help (18 Jan. 1)
- (44) Don't hurt my baby! Pregnant orang-utan protectively hugs her daughter as ruthless Borneo bounty hunters move in for the kill (28 Jan. 1)

Accounting for how speech/thought of others is reported through direct speech, indirect speech and through the use of introducing verbs that frame the information must also be a part of this framework. It is a common complaint that soundbites reproduced in headlines acquire different meanings by virtue of being de-contextualized and re-contextualized.

The textual function in discourse is to make the linguistic elements cohere and constitute a perceivable whole. In the genre of press headlines, one may see fixed patterns and collocations being schematically applied to condense information and attract attention (nominalizations, lack of articles). However, there are some cases in the present sample that were identified by informants as contrived textual devices fitted into headlines to increase the attractiveness of the article. These included unusual textual patterning (unfinished clause, excessive enumeration, graphological deviance), alliteration and lexical allusion, often in the form of pun, coinage or word play. Headlines featuring transformations of titles of films or classical literature, or proverbs or sayings, were observed to be incidental, though relatively effectively applied devices to capture attention. Textual devices were identified in about 20% of cases of the headlines considered as sensationalizing, as below, for example (emphasis added):

- (45) Ed and Yvette cook up '*lasagne-gate*' dinner party plot to unseat Ed Miliband from Labour leadership (29 Jan. 3)
- (46) *Elf and safety* threat to blood donors: Nurses banned from tapping skin to raise veins (13 Jan. 9)

One more feature that is worth noting is the frequent use of metaphorical or metonymic expressions (mostly frozen metaphors or idiomatic expressions) that are supposed to add drama to the coverage, as in the following examples (emphasis added):

- (47) Europe's *war* on British justice: UK *loses* three out of four human rights cases, damning report reveals (11 Jan. 1)
- (48) Cameron: I'll *soften the blow* of child benefit cuts for higher earners ... PM's vow to tackle unfairness in the system (13 Jan. 2)

Metaphors in tabloid newspaper headlines are, obviously, a complex area of study with linguistic, pragmatic and cognitive aspects of metaphorical representations to be explored

(see Molek-Kozakowska, in preparation). Importantly, metaphors have been demonstrated to function to reproduce dominant ideologies, manipulate audiences into supporting policies that are against their best interests and perpetuate prejudices (see Charteris-Black, 2005; Chilton, 1996; Hart, 2010). For the purposes of this study, suffice it to say that metaphors were identified by focus group participants as instrumental in effectively sensationalizing the coverage in the cases when abstract political or economic issues were reported. These were mostly conventionalized metaphorical expressions recycled in the media, as in the example below (emphasis added):

(49) IMF to *boost bailout* find to \$1TRILLION as World Bank *slashes growth* forecast and warns of return to 2008/09 *downturn* (18 Jan. 9)

The sophisticated textual patterning of headlines, whether it is predicated on harmony or disharmony, is an attempt at drawing the recipient into a playful game. For example, a whole gamut of foregrounding devices identified in headlines and discussed in Chovanec (2008) include metaphor, hyperbole, alliteration and assonance, rhyme and reduplication, homonymy and morphological adaptation, nonce words, eye dialect, foreignisms and allusion. The readers' attention is collected in the process of discovering the most relevant meaning. Unfortunately, the cognitive and emotional investments may not always match the actual importance, attractiveness or relevance of information announced in such a contrived and sensationalizing fashion.

Conclusions

The term 'sensationalism' has often been used in debates about the declining quality of contemporary journalism, and as an umbrella term describing various strategies used by popular media outlets to attract broader audiences. The typical approach to sensationalism in media studies research has been through content analysis of major themes and through typologies of news values behind editorial decisions. However, the question that pragma-linguistic mechanisms are frequently or pervasively applied to present stories as more relevant and interesting than is likely to be the case, has been largely left unexplored.

The above analysis offers a categorization, exemplification and discussion of pragma-linguistic elements that are recruited to implement the strategy of sensationalizing. They emerge from the corpus of 120 headlines collected in early 2012 from the *Daily Mail*'s website. The features that pervade the sample material are identified and described in terms of well-delimited pragmatic categories (e.g. illocutions, evaluation and deixis). This constitutes a framework against which a more detailed language-oriented analysis of sensationalism can proceed. However, it is not claimed that sensationalism is an *inherent* characteristic of the specimens of text analyzed, or that it is encoded in newspaper headlines by virtue of specific words and phrases. On the contrary, this study takes into account readers' perceptions of sensationalizing, which are identified in a three-stage process of intersubjective verification (filtered by the *MailOnline*'s 'most read' functionality, by individual surveys and in the course of focus group discussions). The study focuses on those pragma-linguistic devices that have been evaluated by informants as sensationalizing (rated 2–4 on a scale of 0–4). The quantitative and qualitative analysis

of illocutions, themes, narrative formulas, evaluation and interpersonal/textual arrangements of headlines shows how language tends to be recruited to help present an issue that is not of immediate social relevance or personal interest to the respondents as something intriguing, extraordinary and worth exploring. Sensationalism, after all, is a 'compensatory' strategy aimed at legitimizing the time and effort the reader devotes to getting acquainted with the article.

The results of the study must be interpreted as necessarily limited to the sample, the genre and the outlet from which the data were extracted. At the stage of doing a pilot study, such as this project, the framework must be left open-ended and subject to verification. More comparative analyses are needed to determine which other discursive strategies of sensationalizing can be identified in headlines, and to what extent they are applied by various outlets (including the so-called quality outlets). It is comforting to see that some of the strategies identified by respondents here overlap with the ones spotlighted by researchers (see Bednarek and Caple, 2012; Bell, 1991; Conboy, 2006; Fowler, 1991; Richardson, 2007; Van Dijk, 1988). This is indicative of the fact that grasping the nature of sensationalism is a socially relevant type of study and not only an academic pursuit. Also, in the context of some patterns emerging from research on professional practices and institutional priorities behind popular journalism (see Allan, 2004; Conboy, 2002; Richardson, 2007), it is hoped that the study reveals some of the most typical or salient pragma-linguistic instantiations of sensationalizing. The study has also shown how it is possible to design an analytic procedure that bridges textual research and audience research methodologically so that they inform and enhance each other. With respect to its applications, on the one hand, the results and conclusions of this study can be treated as a preliminary empirical substantiation of some of the normative and critical stances in media studies literature; on the other, they may offer some practical information for critical media literacy practitioners.

The present study was contextualized within an approach to sensationalizing as an attention-gathering technique. The current research on newsworthiness and the construction of 'extraordinary events' in news mediation have been departure points in starting to explore the methods of how to attend to *sensationalizing* presentation of news instead of its *sensational* content only. Critically focused yet systematic and empirically grounded research on sensationalism should replace an intuitive treatment of the subject, or a critic's lament about the sorry state of the news media, and, by extension, of Western democracy. That is why efforts need to be made to broaden the scope of research in this direction through advocating multi-disciplinary orientations to popular journalism. For one, it is important to know where exactly sensationalizing devices are located; for another, it is equally crucial to study how they are likely to affect news consumers. However, among various traditions in the study of media effects (see Potter, 2012), there are hardly any approaches that would orient researchers towards closer examinations of the role of language in capturing, directing or diverting people's attention. To finish on a critical note, sensationalism is to be further explored as a strategy resorted to by media outlets to appeal to the broadest possible audience for revenue, to frame the contested news issues in an interested way, to set the agenda to achieve consensus rather than criticality, or to channel attention to trivia at the expense of news items that challenge unequal power relations.

Funding

This research received no specific grant from any funding agency in the public, commercial or not-for-profit sectors.

Notes

1. The figure for early 2012 is over 1,950,000 according to the Audit Bureau of Circulations, <http://www.abc.org.uk>.
2. The other number corresponds to the place of the article on the 'most read' list on the given day.
3. The terminology for stages of written narrative sequence may vary, with *exposition* being called *orientation*, *climax* – *crisis*, and *resolution* – *outcome*. In oral narrative the sequence is typically: *abstract*, *orientation*, *complication*, *evaluation*, *resolution* and *coda* (Labov, 1972, 1997).
4. This specific evaluative function of 'another' is confirmed by Bednarek (2006) in her analysis of news discourse corpus.
5. The contextualization thesis may be useful to explain the relative stylistic simplicity and lack of evaluative markers in some headlines, for example 'Mother drowns baby daughter in bucket while boyfriend watches live on Skype' (6 Jan. 2). Alternatively, the detached factuality of such a headline is deliberately contrived to mirror the cold-bloodedness of the criminal act that is being reported here.

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